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# Umar Shaikh Dies

*‘My own soul is my most faithful friend. My own heart, my truest confidant.’*

—Babur[*]

Babur has mentioned that he was in the Char-Bagh of Andijān when Umar Shaikh met with his tragic end. Babur was designated as the governor of the place back then. He did not wait much; filled with shock and blanketed by deep grief, he rode home with a train of followers and retainers. He desperately wanted to go inside the fort.

But as Babur and his train reached closer to Umar’s Gate, someone took hold of his bridle and moved off towards the Namazgah.

Though he was in just the twelfth year of his life, Babur was quite mature and very thorough with the environment around him. This thought crossed his mind that if a great ruler like Sulṭān Ahmad Mīrzā came to force, the Andijān begs would make over to him and the country. He also thought that if he was taken to Auzkint and the foothills around it, he should go to one of his mother’s (half) brothers, Sulṭān Mahmud Khān or Sulṭān Ahmad Khān.

The news of Babur’s probable departure spread quickly. When Khwaja Maulana-i-qazi and the begs in the fort heard of the same, they sent Khwaja Muhammad and tailor to the Babur. The tailor was probably there to craft the new dress for the new king-to-be. Along with this came an old servant of Umar Shaikh accompanied by the foster father to one of his daughters. The arrival of such personnel and conversation allayed some of Babur’s fear. Khwaja took Babur to the citadel from the Namazgah. As Babur dismounted the horse, Khwaja Maulana-i-qazi and the begs appeared there at once. They tried to counsel the young Babur, who had just lost his beloved father. Soon the horde was engaged in mending towers and ramparts of the fort which had collapsed leading to the accidental demise of Umar Shaikh.

His death also meant that attacks could be anticipated. Everyone feared for Ferghana and the young Babur. Efforts were being made to keep the fort safe.